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as good but it needs to be better than a human being,” says Westgarth.

It is never man vs machine

Although many look at autonomous delivery as a replacement for human workers, as something that’s going to steal their jobs, that might not always be the case. It relieves them from monotonous jobs, gruelling night shifts, extended work hours, and hazardous conditions, freeing human labour for more subjective and valuable tasks.

Westgarth of Starship Technologies said in a recent interview, “We believe that if you can insert value into the economy overall, whatever jobs the economy provides will be of higher value. One of the interesting dynamics that we saw in some environments was that our partners and customers would have a hard

time hiring staff. However, when we posted job openings for staff—technical staff, project management staff or whatever—we would have no trouble hiring them. They would come to us. It is because they saw more opportunity to be involved in an evolving economy. To them it was more attractive working with robotics than making food or delivering food themselves. Both are extremely valuable. But at the end of the day, if we could raise the value of what the human being does versus what this automated machine does, I think that’s a good change in society overall.”

Westgarth cites the example of automation in the automotive industry. The level of automation today is exponentially higher than it was 20-30 years earlier. Superficially, we would think that all this automation would have taken so

many jobs away from human workers. However, there are many more workers in the automotive industry today than before. So, the situation is quite nuanced, and not as easy as saying automation will take away the jobs.

Honestly, you cannot stop technology, not at this stage of growth; so it is better to find a balance. Unlike self-driving cars and heavy vehicles, autonomous last-mile delivery systems, especially mobile robots, seem well-poised for growth in the near term. Trendwatchers believe that more countries will start giving permissions for small and slow AVs to ply on sidewalks, roads, and public places, unlike the hesitance with regards to fast cars. Slowly, the laws of the economy will also play their magic, and find a balance between human-powered and machine-powered tasks. **EFY**